

Two war poems

Both authors fought during the war, and reflected on their experience at the front in some of their poems

The soldier - Rupert Brooke

He was part of a poetical movement known as "georgians" → he is a "georgian poet" → they wrote their poems between 1910 and 1915, when George V was king of the UK

The georgians tended to write about the English countryside → they considered it as the essence of "Englishness" → influence of Wordsworth

Rupert Brooke wrote this before leaving for the front → he is enthusiastic and is a volunteer → he died some weeks later after writing this

This poem is an Italian sonnet → made of 14 lines, grouped into an octave and a sestet (the English sonnet is made of 3 quatrains and a couplet)

At the beginning of the 20th century started to write poems in free verses (no forms, no rhymes) → however Georgian poems were traditional

First line → assonance in "o" and alliteration in "d"

Second verse in "f", in line 3 there is a caesura

Richer dust because it is where an English soldier died

Personification of dust

Reference to the English countryside → English / England = is a polyptoton (repetition of words that share the same root)

The sestet is more metaphysical

Eternal life is a sort of after life

This is an idealistic poem

Dulce et Decorum est - Wilfred Owen

The title is a partial quotation of the Latin poem of Horace (Orazio) → however the quotation is ironic, there is nothing good about war is the message

There are rhymes (so no free verses) → but the verses are iambic pentameters (or maybe soldier in this one not? ask)

4 stanzas

First one sets the scene

"Like old beggars" is a simile → he talks about a group of soldiers → unheroic representation

"Like hags" (old women) →another simile

"Sludge" = mud

Verse 3 and 4 →they have gone over the top, they attacked →now they return to their trenches

"Limped on " = zoppicare

Line 6 →diacope of "all"

In the second one, a gas attack is described

One was not quick enough to wear the mask

"Under a green sea" →simile →the gas turned the air green →he sees his comrade dying

Stanza 3 is about the trauma, that seeing his comrade dying has created in the writer
Consonance of "s", first line

Stanza 4 conveys the message of the whole poem

"Like a devil" →simile, his fate is like the one of a devil

Message is that pro war propaganda should not exist →it convinces young men to leave for the front

The view of line 1 and the one of "my friend" in line 9 make reference to Jessie Pope, a (singoistic = patriotic) poetess and journalist

She became famous during the war for writing several pro war poems and articles on British newspapers, that wanted to convince young British men to go to war

This poem had another title: "To a certain poetess" →then it was changed, but because of this change some scholars believe that "my friend" and "you" can be referred to members of the propaganda system in general

Owen had a similar but different story to Brooke →he was a volunteer too, but then he developed an antiwar position

He got a severe form of shell-shock →he was hospitalized at Craiglockhart hospital (Scottish hospital where shell shocks were sent) →after some months of treatment, they sent him to the front

He died only one week before the end of the war

1920s - 1930s in England

These years have 3 labels:

- the interwar years →purely historical

- the age of anxiety →intellectual atmosphere characterizing these years
- anglo-american modernism →most relevant cultural movement that developed during this period

The UK and US lived these years in very different ways for ? it was tuff →british economy started to have economic problems, and during the inter war years the british empire started collapsing

The real collapse happened after the WWII, but slowly starts here →in 1921 the british empire lost Ireland, its nearest colony →Eire, the Republic of Ireland was established

Northern Ireland remains part of the UK

Now the so known "irish troubles" (1921 - 1994) begin →in 1994 a truce was signed (not a peace treaty)

The irish troubles consisted in a civil war between northern irish catholics and northern irish anglicans →catholics wanted northern ireland to become part of the Eire, while anglicans wanted to remain part of the UK

Many riots and terroristic attacks →that happened in the UK too

The organization that organized these attacks was the I.R.A →irish republic army (catholic terroristic org.), that fought for making northern ireland part of Eire

In the 1930s, according to the Statute of Westminster, some colonies were given the state of "dominions" →not independent, but could be more autonomous →the UK was not able to control its empire with an iron fist anymore →they had to make some concessions

This does not happen however with India →after the WWII, with the process of decolonization, the english empire got dismantled